

STAGE TWELVE • LEADERSHIP

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Twelve • Leadership

PURPOSE

Stage Twelve runs across three sessions — Leadership Foundations, Leading & Developing People, and Advanced & Reflective Leadership — each gets one icebreaker below, built directly from that session's actual content.

Because nearly every participant already has some lived experience with leadership, good and bad, whether or not they've held a formal title, these openers are designed to surface that existing experience in concrete terms before any formal teaching begins. Each one makes the session's core distinction feel like a naming exercise for something participants already know, not an entirely new idea.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Three Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

Leader vs. Boss

TIME: 10 min

1. Ask each participant to silently think of one “boss” (someone with authority they didn't genuinely respect) and one “leader” (someone whose lead they'd follow regardless of title).
2. In pairs, share just one specific behavior that separated the two — not a general vibe, an actual observable action.
3. Collect a few of these behaviors on a whiteboard or shared doc without commentary yet.

WHY THIS WORKS

This produces, in the group's own concrete observations, the exact distinction FIRST P1 is built on — that leadership is earned through trust and behavior, not granted by title.

SESSION 2

The Feedback You Wish You'd Gotten

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “think of a time someone should have given you feedback but didn't — what happened instead?” Quick round-robin, one sentence each.
2. Facilitator notes the pattern out loud: how many of these were genuinely avoided conversations, not just missed opportunities?

WHY THIS WORKS

This surfaces, from lived experience, exactly the cost of avoidance that FIRSTS P16–P18 (feedback and conflict) are about to address directly — making the upcoming content feel like a real answer to a real, shared frustration.

SESSION 3

Influence Without the Title

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask each participant to think of one time they got someone to do something without having any formal authority over them — a classmate, a friend, a colleague at the same level.
2. In pairs, share how you actually did it — what made the person actually go along with it?
3. Quick full-group tally: how many involved a shared goal versus just being personally persuasive?

WHY THIS WORKS

This makes visible, before any formal teaching, that participants already have real (if unnamed) experience with the core skill behind FIRST P22 (Leadership Without Authority) — the session's

opening content becomes a naming exercise, not an entirely new skill.